Upgrade Test - Chatterfang

Live Chatterfang list since 2026-10-15 · Bracket 3 · 1/3 Game Changers · wave 11 trial · 100 cards

Nonland 64 **Avg MV** 2.92 (Pest Infestation counted at 1) **Sacrifice outlets** 5 **Drain payoffs** 12

COMMANDER (1)

1 Chatterfang, Squirrel General 2 3

LANDS (36)

1 Barren Moor
1 Blooming Marsh
1 Bojuka Bog
1 Cabal Coffers
1 Castle Locthwain
1 Command Tower
1 Darkbore Pathway
6 Forest
1 Gaea's Cradle
1 Grim Backwoods
1 High Market
1 Khalni Garden
1 Llanowar Wastes
1 Misty Rainforest
1 Necroblossom Snarl
1 Nurturing Peatland
1 Overgrown Tomb
1 Phyrexian Tower
5 Swamp
1 Tainted Wood
1 Takenuma, Abandoned Mire
1 Three Tree City
1 Twilight Mire
1 Urborg, Tomb of Yawgmoth
1 Verdant Catacombs
1 Woodland Cemetery
1 Yavimaya, Cradle of Growth

RAMP & MANA (15)

1 Azusa, Lost but Seeking 2 3
1 Circle of Dreams Druid 3 3
1 Concordant Crossroads 1
1 Cryptolith Rite 1 2
1 Cultivate 2 3
1 Dryad of the Ilysian Grove 2 3
1 Elvish Mystic 1
1 Gardenize 1 3
1 Llanowar Elves 1
1 Ninja Pizza 2 3
1 Pitiless Plunderer 3 4
1 Sakura-Tribe Elder 1 2
1 Sol Ring 1 1
1 Tireless Provisioner 2 3
1 Twitching Doll 1 2

CARD DRAW (5)

1 Black Market Connections 2 3
1 Bloodline Recollector 1 2
1 Moldervine Reclamation 3 5
1 Skullclamp 1 1
1 Sylvan Library 1 2

REMOVAL & INTERACTION (5)

1 Assassin's Trophy 2
1 Beast Within 2 3
1 Heroic Intervention 1 2
1 Plumb the Forbidden 1 2
1 Tear Asunder 1 2

BOARD WIPES (2)

1 Blasphemous Edict 3 5
1 The Meathook Massacre X 2

TOKEN ENGINES (14)

1 Academy Manufactor 3 3
1 Avenger of Zendikar 5 7
1 Bilbo, Fellow Conspirator 2 3
1 Bitterblossom 1 2
1 Camellia, the Seedmiser 1 3
1 Chatterstorm 1 2
1 Esika's Chariot 3 4
1 Hazel of the Rootbloom 2 4
1 Peregrin Took 2 3
1 Scute Swarm 2 3
1 Second Harvest 2 4
1 Springleaf Parade X 2
1 The Unbeatable Squirrel Girl 1 4
1 Tippy-Toe, Terrific Partner 3 4

TOKEN DOUBLERS (2)

1 Doubling Season 4 5
1 Parallel Lives 3 4

SACRIFICE OUTLETS (5)

1 Ashnod's Altar 3 3
1 Priest of Forgotten Gods 1 2
1 Warren Soultrader 2 3
1 Witch's Oven 1 1
1 Yawgmoth, Thran Physician 2 4

DRAIN PAYOFFS (12)

1 Bastion of Remembrance 2 3
1 Blood Artist 1 2
1 Cauldron of Essence 1 3
1 Dina, Soul Steeper 2
1 Marionette Apprentice 1 2
1 Mirkwood Bats 3 4
1 Nadier's Nightblade 2 3
1 Prosperous Innkeeper 1 2
1 Starscape Cleric 1 2
1 Valley Rotcaller 1 2
1 Vito, Thorn of the Dusk Rose 2 3
1 Zulaport Cutthroat 1 2

FINISHERS & EQUIPMENT (3)

1 Bloodletter of Aclazotz 1 4
1 Craterhoof Behemoth 5 8
1 Gruesome Fate 2 3

UPGRADE TEST (CHATTERFANG) — PILOT'S GAMEPLAN

> Playtest fork of `decks/chatterfang`, taken **2026-09-25** and tuned in waves since. Parent list untouched. Every wave, with its grounds, is in `research/decisions.md` and on the proposal page: https://claude.ai/artifact/Qgp3cNcdmKWoE8fPZMxvQB **Updated 2026-10-15 for wave 11 (a trial).** In: Pest Infestation, Priest of Forgotten Gods. Out: Black Market Connections, Woe Strider. Undo rows are in `research/decisions.md`. **Updated 2026-09-29 for wave 10.** In: Chatterstorm, Verdant Command, Esika's Chariot, Deep Forest Hermit, Warren Soultrader, Azusa, Lost but Seeking. Out: Nature's Lore, Arcane Signet, Carrion Feeder, Village Rites, Concordant Crossroads, Oracle of Mul Daya.

0. The one-paragraph version

You are a **mana and body economy**. Chatterfang turns every token you make into two, Cryptolith Rite and Gaea's Cradle turn that board into mana, and the sacrifice outlets turn it into damage. Drain is the primary plan — but **attacking is close to free here, so treat a wide board as a real second route.** A token that gets blocked and trades fires every death trigger you own (Blood Artist, Zulaport, Bastion, Cauldron of Essence, Mirkwood Bats, Nadier's Nightblade, Marionette Apprentice), and the life each one gains feeds Dina, Starscape Cleric and Vito. **Either way you are draining.** Craterhoof, Blasphemous Edict and Gruesome Fate each turn a wide board into a win without touching the combo. Wave 10 added the thing the deck was short of: cards that make **several tokens in one turn from nothing** (Chatterstorm, Verdant Command, Esika's Chariot, Deep Forest Hermit). Wave 11 added Pest Infestation to that group.

1. The curve you actually have

	MV≤1	MV2	MV3	MV4	MV5	MV6+	avg
Nonland (64)	6	20	22	10	4	2	**2.92**

The tools count Pest Infestation at MV 1. At X=2 it costs 5, which puts the real average near 2.99.

Heavier than the parent (2.73). Wave 10 made it heavier on paper (2.84 → 2.97, MV ≤ 2 27 → 24), but the cards that left at MV 1 made no tokens and no mana, and the ones that arrived make four to eight bodies each. **The thing to watch and report back is the turn you win on**, which was 8 to 10 before this wave.

2. The three numbers to track

1. **Tokens created this turn** — not tokens on board. Mirkwood Bats triggers **once per token

created** (CR 603.2c), Prosperous Innkeeper gains 1 per creature entering, and Vito converts each of those gains. Sixteen tokens entering at once is sixteen separate Bats triggers.

1. **Tokens on board** — everything else scales off it: Gaea's Cradle, Three Tree City, Circle of

Dreams Druid, Gruesome Fate, Valley Rotcaller, Craterhoof, Blasphemous Edict.

1. **Is Bloodletter out, and is it your turn?** If yes, every number above doubles.

> **Three lifegain converters:** Dina and Starscape Cleric (1 to *each* opponent per gain) and Vito (that much to one opponent). Every 1-life gain is a separate event for each of them, so many small gains beat one big one.

3. Opening

T1–T2: Llanowar Elves or Elvish Mystic (turn-2 Chatterfang), Sol Ring, Ravenous Squirrel, Bitterblossom, Skullclamp, Sakura-Tribe Elder, Cryptolith Rite. Hold **Chatterstorm** and **Verdant Command** for after Chatterfang lands: each Squirrel they make brings a second one.

T3 — the fork:

- No board → **Chatterfang**. He is the engine; everything after him is worth double.
- Board already → **Cryptolith Rite** (every token taps for mana) or **Parallel Lives**.
- Spare lands in hand → **Azusa** or **Dryad**, with a landfall payoff already out.

T4–T6: deploy a drain payoff under an existing board, not the other way around. A Blood Artist with nothing to sacrifice is a 0/1. **Yawgmoth is the exception** — he converts spare bodies into cards the moment he lands, so he is never a dead draw.

Mulligans. Keep 3 lands with both colours and a 1–2 drop. Ship hands with no token source before turn 3. At avg MV 2.92 this list wants the third land more than the parent did.

4. The sacrifice decision tree

Sacrifice when: you have a free outlet and *any* drain payoff; in response to targeted removal; in response to a wrath (Plumb the Forbidden converts the board into a fistful of cards).

Do NOT sacrifice when: no payoff is on the battlefield; or **Vito, Dina, Starscape Cleric or Prosperous Innkeeper would die in the same event**. "Whenever you gain life" and "whenever a creature enters" have no look-back, so they must be alive as each gain happens. Blood Artist, Zulaport, Bastion and Cauldron of Essence are fine dying in the same wipe, because dies-triggers look back in time (CR 603.10a).

5. The engine to look for

Free outlet + Blood Artist + Zulaport + Bastion + Cauldron of Essence. Each token sacrificed is 1 to *each* opponent four times over, plus Mirkwood Bats for a fifth, plus Marionette Apprentice for a sixth if it's out. The four life gains then fire Dina and Starscape Cleric for 4 to each opponent and Vito for 4 at one, if they're out.

> **Roughly 6 to the whole table per 1/1**, doubled by Bloodletter. Cauldron of Essence is on an **artifact**, so unlike the rest it survives Blasphemous Edict and every creature wipe.

Yawgmoth, Thran Physician is the new engine card. Pay 1 life, sacrifice a creature: a −1/−1 counter *and draw a card*. It is a free outlet, a draw engine and removal in one, bounded only by your life total. With Skullclamp out, a −1/−1 counter kills the clamped 1/1 and draws two more.

Warren Soultrader is a Pitiless Plunderer you trigger yourself. Pay 1 life, sacrifice another creature, create a Treasure. That Treasure is a token event, so the whole §5c chain runs on every sacrifice: a Squirrel from Chatterfang, a Food each from Peregrin and Tippy-Toe, and Manufactor's split. It is also the deck's any-colour outlet. See §8d for the loop.

Priest of Forgotten Gods is an outlet that pays you back, once a turn. Tap it and sacrifice two other creatures. Each opponent you target loses 2 life and sacrifices a creature of their choice, and you add 💀💀 and draw a card. It works at instant speed, so use it in response to removal or a wrath, but it needs a turn to lose summoning sickness. It is an edict, not a wipe, because each opponent gives up their worst creature. Two sacrifices are two deaths, so every payoff above fires twice per activation. It taps, and the list has no untap effect (checked 2026-10-15), so it can't repeat in a turn and is not the outlet for the loops.

Pest Infestation is a seed you can size. ⓧⓧ🌳: X=2 costs 5 and makes 4 Pests plus 4 Squirrels from Chatterfang. That is one creation event, so without doublers Mirkwood Bats fires 8 times and Prosperous Innkeeper gains 8. Each Pest that dies gains 1 life, which is its own event for Dina, Starscape Cleric and Vito. The destroy half is "up to X", so choose no targets to leave your own Altar, Doubling Season and Cryptolith Rite alone, or aim it at an opponent's artifacts and enchantments. It is a sorcery.

5b. Landfall — every land is a token and a Squirrel

Chatterfang adds a Squirrel to every token, and four cards make a token per land: Tireless Provisioner (Food or Treasure), Tireless Tracker (a Clue), Scute Swarm (a copy of itself at six lands), Avenger of Zendikar (a Plant per land on arrival, then a counter per land after). **Verdant Catacombs** and **Misty Rainforest** are two landfall triggers each; crack them on your own turn with payoffs out. **Cultivate** is two (one now, one on a later drop) and **Sakura-Tribe Elder** is one plus a free death.

Dryad of the Ilysian Grove (one extra drop) and **Azusa** (two) only matter when you hold a spare land after your normal drop, which is about 27% of turn 4s and 16% of turn 5s. **Cultivate is what puts that spare land in your hand**, so the best landfall turn is Cultivate, then Dryad or Azusa, then two land drops with Provisioner and Scute Swarm out. Every trigger is its own token event, so each one runs the whole §5c chain.

5c. The ordering law — memorise this one

When several replacement effects want the same token-creation event, **you choose the order** (CR 616.1), and the order changes the total by a large factor. Always:

> **Peregrin Took → Tippy-Toe → Bilbo → Academy Manufactor → Chatterfang LAST**

Fixed adders, then splitters, then the multiplier. Getting Chatterfang first on a 15-Treasure event costs you **30 tokens**.

Peregrin Took and Tippy-Toe are not Food-adders — both read "*if one or more **tokens** would be created, those tokens plus an additional Food token are created instead.*" They fire on **every** token event of any kind and add one Food each, per event. That Food is untapped, so it is this turn's mana through Ninja Pizza.

Worked: one plain "create a Food" with Peregrin + Tippy-Toe + Bilbo + Manufactor + Chatterfang is **36 tokens**. From one **Treasure**, with both doublers as well, it is **120 tokens** — 20 Clues, 20 Foods, 20 Treasures and 60 Squirrels — and 120 Mirkwood Bats triggers.

Why the order is what it is (verified 2026-09-26). Doubling Season and Parallel Lives are uniform ×2 and **commute** — they can go anywhere, including after Chatterfang, and the total is identical. The binding constraint is that **Chatterfang must come after Academy Manufactor and Bilbo**, because those two replace only Clue/Food/Treasure tokens and cannot see Squirrels. "Chatterfang last" is still the right thing to remember at the table — it always reaches the maximum — just don't reason that a doubler placed after him is wasted. It isn't.

Bilbo before Manufactor is correct whenever `3 × Foods > total Clue/Food/Treasure` in the event, which is nearly always true here because Peregrin and Tippy-Toe are feeding it Foods.

6. Sequencing within your turn

1. **Upkeep:** Bitterblossom makes a Faerie; Deep Forest Hermit loses a time counter.
2. **Start of main 1:** Gardenize adds its mana.
3. **Main 1: Bloodletter FIRST if you have it.** Then landfall payoffs, **then** your land drop(s),

then the other token makers, then the payoff. **Chatterstorm goes last among your spells**: every spell cast before it is another copy, and every copy is a separate token event.

1. **Tap for value before you sacrifice** — Gaea's Cradle, Three Tree City and Circle of Dreams

Druid all read the board, and a sacrificed Squirrel is one less mana. Cryptolith Rite means a token can tap for mana *and then* be sacrificed.

1. **Sacrifice in the second main**, once the board is as wide as it will get.
2. **Ninja Pizza** makes a free Food at the beginning of your second main — that is a full token

event, so it runs the whole §5c cascade.

7. The kill — four routes, none of them the combo

Blasphemous Edict for 🖤 when there are 13+ creatures on the battlefield (**all players count**, and the cost is locked when you cast it — they cannot shrink the board in response). You choose your own thirteen; opponents lose their boards; you bank **thirteen** death triggers that look back in time. Keep Chatterfang out of your thirteen so the board rebuilds.

Craterhoof Behemoth. X is the *number* of creatures and includes Craterhoof itself, determined once on resolution. ⚠️ **It grants trample, NOT haste.** Craterhoof has haste itself, but tokens you made this turn get +X/+X and still cannot attack, and Concordant Crossroads left in wave 10. They do count toward X. **Build the board the turn before, then cast Craterhoof.** Deploy every token *before* letting the trigger resolve; creatures made afterwards get nothing.

Valley Rotcaller. When it attacks, each opponent loses X, where X is your other Squirrels, Bats, Lizards and Rats. Every Chatterfang Squirrel counts, and so do Mirkwood Bats and Starscape Cleric. X is locked on resolution (see §9).

Gruesome Fate with 20 creatures is 20 to each opponent, 40 with Bloodletter. **Cast it before you sacrifice** — it counts creatures you control.

8. The finish — the combos are still here

8a. The fast loop — Chatterfang + Pitiless Plunderer (live from turn 4)

With **Chatterfang + Pitiless Plunderer** out and one Squirrel:

1. Activate Chatterfang: 🖤, sacrifice 1 Squirrel → target creature gets +1/−1.
2. The Squirrel dies → Plunderer makes a **Treasure** → Chatterfang adds a **Squirrel**.
3. The Treasure pays the next 🖤. Repeat as many times as you choose.

> **Per iteration: one death, −1 toughness on a creature you target, nothing spent.** Every drainer fires each time. With **Ashnod's Altar** as the outlet instead, each death also nets ◇◇.

- **Aim the −1s at the biggest blocker or commander first.** The loop is also a one-sided sweeper.
- **No opposing creature to target?** Target the Squirrel you are about to sacrifice — targets are

chosen before costs are paid (CR 601.2c, 601.2h), so the ability does nothing, but the sacrifice already happened and Plunderer still triggers.

- ⚠️ Assembles on **turn 4**. Tell the table it's in the deck.

8b. The Food loop (assembles ~turn 8+)

Camellia, the Seedmiser + Peregrin Took or Tippy-Toe + Ashnod's Altar, plus one Food and any drain payoff. Each iteration, all inside **one step** (mana empties between steps):

1. Sacrifice a Squirrel to **Ashnod's Altar** → ◇◇. *(a creature died — every drainer fires)*
2. Crack a **Food**: pay 2, tap it, sacrifice it → gain 3 life. *(Vito drains 3)*

With **Ninja Pizza** out, skip the 2 — Foods just tap and sacrifice for a mana of any colour.

1. **Camellia** triggers off that sacrifice and makes a Squirrel.
2. **Apply the adders first, Chatterfang last** (§5c).
3. Repeat as many times as you choose.

> **Net per iteration: +2 Squirrels or better, Food replaced, mana neutral or positive, +3 life, one creature dies.** Still lethal with a drain payoff even if your commander is gone.

⚠️ Announce each iteration; opponents get priority between them. ⚠️ New Squirrels are summoning sick — they cannot attack, but they **can** be sacrificed.

With Bilbo and Academy Manufactor out the returned Food becomes Food + Treasure, then one of each, so every iteration is many times bigger.

8c. No combo? Then the big turn

The Unbeatable Squirrel Girl. `1🌳🌳: create X Squirrels, where X is the number of Squirrels you control` — Chatterfang matches it, so each activation roughly **triples** your count.

Squirrels before	After one activation
5	15
10	30
20	60

Mana from **Circle of Dreams Druid** (one tap = one mana per creature), **Cryptolith Rite** (older tokens only), **Gaea's Cradle**, **Three Tree City** naming Squirrel, and **Hazel of the Rootbloom**, whose ability taps tokens *as a cost* and so ignores summoning sickness.

Then convert with Craterhoof, Gruesome Fate, Blasphemous Edict, or the Altar. **Second Harvest** doubles the board before any of it.

8d. The Soultrader loop: Chatterfang + Warren Soultrader (live from turn 4)

With **Chatterfang + Warren Soultrader** out and one Squirrel:

1. Pay 1 life and sacrifice the Squirrel to Soultrader.
2. Soultrader makes a **Treasure**, and Chatterfang adds a **Squirrel** to that event.
3. Repeat with the new Squirrel as many times as you choose.

> **Per iteration: one death, +1 Treasure, board size unchanged, 1 life paid.** Mirkwood Bats fires three times (two tokens created, one sacrificed). Any payoff that gains life on a death (Zulaport, Bastion, Cauldron of Essence, Blood Artist, Nadier's Nightblade) pays the life back, which makes it free. With Pitiless Plunderer also out, each death is a second Treasure.

- Unlike 8a it costs no 💀 and needs no target. It does need **another** creature, so Soultrader

can't sacrifice itself.

- ⚠️ Assembles on **turn 4**, the same as 8a. Tell the table it's in the deck.

9. Mistakes to avoid

1. **Sacrificing with no payoff out.** The most common way to lose this deck.
2. **Applying Chatterfang before the adders.** See §5c — it is the single most expensive misplay

here, and it is easy to get backwards.

1. **Expecting Craterhoof to grant haste.** It grants trample. Concordant Crossroads is out of the

deck, so this turn's tokens always sit at home.

1. **Sacrificing in response to Valley Rotcaller's attack trigger.** X is locked on *resolution*, not

on declare-attackers — let the trigger resolve first or X shrinks.

1. **Forgetting Chatterfang applies to non-creature tokens.** Treasures, Foods, Clues, Servos — every

one brings a Squirrel. Deadly Dispute makes two bodies, not zero.

1. **Wiping while Vito, Dina, Starscape Cleric or Innkeeper are on board.** They die and give you

nothing.

1. **Casting Gruesome Fate after the board is gone.**
2. **Tapping Gaea's Cradle or Circle of Dreams Druid after you sacrifice.** Tap first.
3. **Forgetting Mirkwood Bats triggers twice per token** — once on create, once on sacrifice — and

once per token, not once per batch.

1. **Including Chatterfang in your own thirteen for Blasphemous Edict.** You choose; don't pick him.
2. **Counting on Circle of Dreams Druid or Ninja Pizza's Foods the turn they land.** Circle is

summoning sick without haste; a real Food token is a noncreature artifact and is *not*.

1. **Casting Chatterstorm first.** It copies once for each spell cast *before* it this turn.
2. **Attacking with Esika's Chariot the turn it lands.** A Vehicle that came under your control this

turn can't attack, and Crossroads no longer gives it haste. It makes its two Cats on arrival either way.

5d. The Pitiless Plunderer loop — the actual kill, and its two traps

Verified 2026-09-28. With **Chatterfang + Pitiless Plunderer + Academy Manufactor + Bilbo + Peregrin Took + Tippy-Toe** out, one creature dying is lethal in a way the table cannot see coming.

One creature dies → 30 tokens. Pitiless Plunderer makes 1 Treasure; apply in this order:

Step	Effect	Running total
—	1 Treasure created	1
1	Peregrin Took (+1 Food)	2
2	Tippy-Toe (+1 Food)	3
3	Bilbo (each Food → +1 Treasure)	5
4	Academy Manufactor (5 C/F/T → 5 of each)	15
5	Chatterfang (+15 Squirrels)	**30**

5 Clues, 5 Foods, 5 Treasures, 15 Squirrels. **30 is the maximum** — confirmed by exhausting all nine legal orderings. Manufactor-before-Bilbo gives 24; Chatterfang early gives 16. Bilbo *cannot* be chosen first (no Food in the event yet, so it is not applicable) — you cannot waste it by accident.

Then sacrifice the 15 Squirrels to Chatterfang for 💀. They die simultaneously, so Pitiless Plunderer triggers **15 separate times** (CR 603.2c), and each trigger is **its own token-creation event** — so the whole chain re-applies in full to every one of them (CR 614.5 gives a fresh opportunity per event). **15 × 30 = 450 tokens, 225 of them Squirrels**, for one 💀. With Mirkwood Bats that is **450 damage to each opponent**.

It is a **growing loop, not a draw** — activating the ability is optional (CR 104.4b), so you choose when to stop, and you must name a number (CR 732.2a).

The two traps, both in your own cost:

1. **"Sacrifice X Squirrels" does not exclude your own pieces.** Chatterfang (Squirrel Warrior) and

Tippy-Toe (Squirrel Hero) are both legal Squirrels — so are Camellia, Ravenous Squirrel and Squirrel Girl. Feed any of them to the cost and the engine stops for every later trigger. **Sacrifice only the 1/1 tokens.**

1. **The ability needs a target,** and "*Target creature gets +X/-X*" is unrestricted — with no

opponent creature you must point it at your own. **Name one of the Squirrels you are about to sacrifice**: targets are chosen before costs are paid, so it is legal on announcement and gone by resolution, and CR 608.2b removes the ability without the –X touching anything you kept. Better still, **target a spare Squirrel you are not sacrificing** — it dies to the –X, and that is one more Plunderer trigger and 30 more tokens.

Two more things to know. Opponents get priority between each of the 15 resolutions, so removing Manufactor or Chatterfang mid-cascade shrinks the payoff (CR 614.4 — the effect must exist before the event). And 75 Foods means 25 activations of Peregrin Took's "Sacrifice three Foods: Draw a card" — **do not reflexively cash them**, CR 104.3c kills you for drawing from an empty library.

Interactive version: https://claude.ai/artifact/Gti7ru3nZXYFh59YJXCmyD — toggle which pieces are actually on board and it solves the ordering for one event, then adds up what sacrificing it deals. It does not run the repeat; multiply by the number of deaths yourself, as in the table above.